# Medival India:The Cholas

## 📍 NAMES OF KINGS IN CHRONOLOGICAL ORDER ⏳📌

- 🗺️➡️ **The Sequence:**
    - Vijayalaya ➔ Parantaka I ➔ Rajaraja I ➔ Rajendra Chola. 👑 (Derived from the text sequence)

## 🧠 High-Yield Fact Table (The Ultimate MCQ Solver) 📌

| Term / Name / Location 🏷️ | Direct Fact / Detail 📝 |
|---|---|
| **Tondamandalam** | The Tamil country brought under Chola control after defeating the Pallavas and weakening the Pandyans. |
| **Tiruvalangadu Copper Plates** | A set of 31 copper plates recording Rajendra Chola's gift of Palaiyanur village to the Siva temple in Trivellore. |
| **Tiger, Umbrella, Fly-whisks** | The Royal emblem of the Cholas (Tiger) alongside symbols of royalty found on the circular copper seal. |
| **Fishes, Bow, Boar** | Emblems of the Pandyas (fishes), Cheras (bow), and Eastern Chalukyas (boar) proving Rajendra Chola conquered them. |
| **Anbil, Karandi & Kanyakumari** | Copper-plate grants and a stone inscription giving a long list of rulers indicating the origin of the Chola dynasty. |

| Term / Name / Location 🏷️ | Direct Fact / Detail 📝 |
|---|---|
| **Uttaramerur Inscription** | Gives specific information on village administration, taxation, and land revenue. |
| **Museum of Leyden (Holland)** | Preserves copper-plate grants of Parantaka Chola and Parakesari Uttama Chola. |
| **Gopuram & Garbhagriha** | The gateway of the temple and the main shrine where images of gods/goddesses were kept, respectively. |
| **Mandapa & Vimanas** | The audience hall for prayers and the massive towers that are chief features of Chola temples. |
| **Brihadeshwara Temple** | Located at Thanjavur, dedicated to Lord Shiva, built by Rajaraja I; a prime specimen of Dravidian architecture. |
| **Karanas** | Synchronised movements of hands and feet at the same time in Bharatanatyam; 81 of 108 are depicted in the temple. |
| **Ashta-dikpaalakas** | Guardians of eight directions; idols of which are featured in the Brihadeshwara temple. |
| **Vijayalaya & Parantaka I** | Founder who established Chola rule in Thanjavur (9th century), and his grandson who conquered Madurai. |

| Term / Name / Location 🏷️ | Direct Fact / Detail 📝 |
| --- | --- |
| **Rajaraja I** | Brilliant general who campaigned in many directions, attacking Pandyas, Cheras, and taking territories in Sri Lanka. |

## 📍 MEDIEVAL INDIA (A) THE CHOLAS (Introduction) 📌

- 🗺️➡️ **The Ultimate Revision Flow Chart:**
  - The southern part of the Indian peninsula situated south of the Krishna river was home to three powerful kingdoms—the Cheras, the Pandyas and the Cholas ➔ the most powerful of the three were the Cholas ➔ the Chola Empire which arose in the ninth century brought under its control a large part of the peninsula ➔ Cholas developed a powerful navy which enabled them to develop India's sea-trade in the Indian Ocean and to conquer Sri Lanka and the Maldive Islands ➔ by the end of the 9th century, the Cholas defeated the Pallavas of Kanchi and weakened the Pandyans bringing the Tamil country (Tondamandalam) under their control. 🌊⚔️

## 📍 COPPER-PLATE INSCRIPTIONS OF RAJENDRA CHOLA 📌

- 🗺️➡️ **The Ultimate Revision Flow Chart:**
  - The Tiruvalangadu copper plates of Rajendra Chola record his gift of the Palaiyanur village to the Tiruvalangadu Siva temple in the present day Trivellore district ➔ they are a set of 31 copper plates, the ends of which are secured by a big circular copper seal with the royal emblem of the Chola dynasty ➔ the legend around the emblem proclaimed in Sanskrit reads: "Hail, Prosperity! This is Parakesarivarman Rajendra Chola's edict to be borne on the glittering jewels of the row of royal diadems" ➔ the seal is a beautiful work of art having a tiger (the emblem of the Cholas), an umbrella and two fly-whisks (representing royalty), a swastika and two lamps (auspicious symbols) ➔ besides, it has two vertical fishes

(the royal emblem of the Pandyas), a bow (the Cheras' emblem), and the boar (eastern Chalukyas' emblem), signifying that Rajendra Chola had conquered the Pandyas, the Cheras and the eastern Chalukyas. 📜🐅

📍 **SOURCES (Inscriptions)** 📌

- 🗺️➡️ **The Ultimate Revision Flow Chart:**
    - The main source of information for the history of the Chola period is the large number of inscriptions of that period ➔ Chola ruler Rajaraja I started and conceived the idea of prefixing to his inscriptions the main achievements of his reign ➔ the example of Rajaraja I was followed by his successors as well ➔ consequently, there exists a formal record of the transactions (toy) made by each Chola ruler ➔ inscriptions of the Cholas are in the form of Copper-plate grants, stone inscriptions and inscriptions made on the walls and pillars of temples ➔ Copper-plate grants known as Anbil and Karandi as well as the Kanyakumari stone inscription give a long list of rulers indicating the origin of the Chola dynasty ➔ another set of Copper-plates contains 31 copper sheets written in Sanskrit and Tamil recording a grant made to a temple by Rajendra Chola I ➔ inscriptions provide the following information: (i) They tell us about the Chola administration (example: the Uttaramerur inscription gives information on the village administration, taxation and land revenue) ➔ (ii) They record gifts and endowments (property) to temples and brahmanas (Copper-plate inscriptions are records of grants of villages, plots of land or other privileges to individuals or institutions) ➔ preserved in the Museum of Leyden in Holland (Parantaka Chola and Parakesari Uttama Chola are among the most important) ➔ (iii) They inform us about the construction of a temple or the setting up (offer) of a new image of the deity ➔ (iv) Some inscriptions have royal orders on taxation and land revenue, resolutions of village assemblies, judgements delivered against persons guilty of theft, murder and other crimes ➔ inscriptions on temple walls served the purpose of public

registrations such as the record of sales, mortgages and other forms of transfers of property rights in village lands. ✍️ 🏛️

📍 **SOURCES (The Brihadeshwara Temple)** 📌

- 🗺️➡️ **The Ultimate Revision Flow Chart:**
    - The Cholas built a number of temples ➔ the gateway of the temple was called 'gopuram' ➔ the main shrine was known as the 'garbhagriha' where the images of gods and goddesses were kept (images made either of stone or bronze) ➔ the 'mandapa' or the audience hall was a place where people gathered for prayers, built in front of the main shrine ➔ chief features of Chola temples are their massive vimanas or towers and spacious courtyards ➔ best example of Chola temple is the Brihadeshwara temple, dedicated to Lord Shiva, located at Thanjavur and built by the Chola King, Rajaraja I ➔ it is one of the best specimens of Dravidian style of architecture ➔ main structure has a great vimana or tower which rises to a height of 66 metres, crowned by a massive dome consisting of a single block of stone (7.6 metres high weighing about 80 tons) ➔ main temple is built of 1,30,000 tons of granite and is covered from base to top with sculptures and decorative mouldings ➔ the shrine houses a gigantic Shiva Lingam, cut in a monolithic rock about 8.87 metres high ➔ temple has many structures such as a Nandi Pavilion, a pillared portico and a large assembly hall ➔ Brihadeshwara temple is the finest monument of a splendid period of South Indian history and most beautiful specimen of Tamil architecture (declared a World Heritage Site by UNESCO) ➔ temple provides following info: (i) temple has a portrait of Rajaraja Chola paying obeisance (respect) to Lord Nataraja (undoubtedly the first known instance of a royal portrait) ➔ (ii) Inscriptions in the temple point towards Rajaraja as the chief architect of the temple ➔ (iii) Depictions of dancers showing eighty one of hundred and eight karanas (synchronised movements at the same time of hands and feet) in Bharatanatyam are carved here, showing the temple was a platform for talented dancers to showcase their talent (first of their kind) ➔ (iv) inscriptions

mention different kinds of jewels used in the Chola period (twenty three different types of pearls, eleven varieties of diamonds and rubies mentioned) ➔ (v) It is one of the few temples that have idols of Ashta-dikpaalakas (Guardians of eight directions). 🛕💎

## 📍 CHOLA RULERS (Vijayalaya, Parantaka I & Rajaraja I) 📌

- 🗺️➡️ **The Ultimate Revision Flow Chart:**
    - Chola ruler Vijayalaya established Chola rule in Tamil land, with Thanjavur as his capital, during the middle of the ninth century ➔ after his death, his grandson Parantaka I became the king, conquered Madurai and defeated the Pandyas and the rulers of Lanka ➔ by the 11th century AD the Chola power had reached the height of its glory with Rajaraja I and his son, Rajendra Chola being the two prominent rulers of this dynasty ➔ Rajaraja I was a brilliant general and campaigned in many directions ➔ he attacked the kingdoms of the Pandyas and the Cheras as well as parts of Mysore ➔ Rajaraja annexed parts of Deccan and overran Vengi to prove the strength of the Chola power ➔ took some territories of Mysore, Travancore and Coorg (Sri lanka) ➔ the coasts of Kerala, Ceylon (Sri Lanka) and the Maldive Islands had become rich through the money that came to them from overseas trade ➔ India sent textiles, spices and precious stones to the West Asian countries ➔ people who came from Western Asia to trade in these goods were the Arab merchants, who exchanged goods. 🌍🚢

## 🧠 High-Yield Fact Table (The Ultimate MCQ Solver) 📌

| Term / Name / Location 🏷️ | Direct Fact / Detail 📝 |
|---|---|
| **Cholamandal** | The Chola kingdom, whose prosperity increased through trade; the word *Coromandel* is derived from it. |

| Term / Name / Location 🏷️ | Direct Fact / Detail 📝 |
|---|---|
| **Rajarajeshwara Temple** | Temple of Lord Shiva at Thanjavur built by Rajaraja I; its walls are inscribed with his main works. |
| **Mahipala** | The king of Bengal defeated by the Chola army under Rajendra Chola's generals. |
| **Jatavarman Sundara Chola** | The title given to one of Rajendra Chola's sons when appointed as Viceroy of the southern states. |
| **Gangaikonda** | Title adopted by Rajendra Chola to commemorate (honour) his victory up to the Ganga river. |
| **Gangaikonda-Cholapuram** | The new capital built by Rajendra Chola in the present state of Tamil Nadu. |
| **Straits of Malacca** | Trade route held by the kingdom of Shrivijaya (modern day Indonesia). |
| **Shrivijaya** | Kingdom defeated by Rajendra Chola's huge navy after its merchants created problems for Indian merchants. |
| **Mandalams** | Provinces into which the Chola empire was divided. |
| **Valanadu & Nadu** | Further subdivisions of the mandalams (provinces). |
| **Ur** | Common type of village assembly where land was held by all classes of people. |

| Term / Name / Location 🏷️ | Direct Fact / Detail 📝 |
|---|---|
| **Sabha** | An exclusively brahmin assembly of villages where all land belonged to the brahmins. |
| **Nagaram** | Assembly of merchants belonging to localities where traders and merchants were in a dominant position. |
| **Devadaya / Devadana** | Huge lands donated to the temples which participated in inland and overseas trade. |
| **Dravidian Style** | The architectural style in which most of the Chola temples were built. |
| **Garbhagriha** | The sanctum at the heart of the temple where the main deity is installed. |
| **Vimana** | A tall pyramidal tower rising directly above the garbhagriha; the most striking feature of Chola temples. |
| **Shikhara & Kalasha** | The dome-like structure crowning the vimana, topped with the symbolic finial (*kalasha*). |
| **Ardha Mandapa** | Structure in front of the sanctum leading to the spacious *mandapa* (pillared hall). |
| **Prakara** | An enclosed corridor surrounding the sanctum meant for circumambulation. |

| Term / Name / Location 🏷️ | Direct Fact / Detail 📝 |
|---|---|
| **Nandi Mandapa** | Houses the sacred bull Nandi facing the main shrine in large temples. |

## 📍 RAJARAJA I & HIS NAVAL EXPEDITION 📌

- 🗺️➡️ **The Ultimate Revision Flow Chart:**
  - Foreigners brought wealth to India through their trade (exchanging money for goods) ➔ Rajaraja I was aware of the importance of controlling the sea ➔ decided to show his strength along the coasts of South India ➔ so he took out a naval expedition (journey for basis purpose) and attacked both Sri Lanka and the Maldive Islands ➔ he conquered the northern half of Sri Lanka ➔ built the Rajarajeshwara temple of Lord Shiva at Thanjavur ➔ on walls of this temple are inscribed main works of Rajaraja I ➔ under his rule, Cholas became supreme power in Southern India ➔ increase in trade brought prosperity to kingdom Cholamandal ➔ word Coromandel has been derived from Cholamandal. 🌊🚢

## 📍 RAJENDRA CHOLA 📌

- 🗺️➡️ **The Ultimate Revision Flow Chart:**
  - Rajendra succeeded his father Rajaraja I and continued his policies ➔ invaded and annexed the whole island of Sri Lanka (Sri Lanka not able to free herself for another 50 years) ➔ campaigns were daring ➔ armies marched up east coast of India through Odisha and up to Ganga river ➔ Rajendra Chola himself led army up to Godavari and thereafter generals took charge ➔ Chola army defeated Mahipala (king of Bengal) ➔ defeated both Pandyas and Cheras effectively establishing Chola dominance over southern states ➔ appointed one of his sons as Viceroy with title Jatavarman Sundara Chola ➔ to commemorate (honour) this victory he adopted title of Gangaikonda and built new capital Gangaikonda-Cholapuram in Tamil Nadu ➔ most daring campaign was in South-

East Asia ➔ Indian merchants traded with South-East Asia and southern China through Straits of Malacca held by kingdom of Shrivijaya (modern day Indonesia) ➔ merchants of Shrivijaya began creating problems so Indian merchants appealed to Rajendra Chola for help ➔ he sent out huge navy and defeated Shrivijaya king ➔ as a result Indian trade with South-East Asia and southern China continued thereby greatly enriching the Chola kingdom ➔ he built magnificent palaces and beautiful temples at his new capital Gangaikonda-Cholapuram. ⚔️👑

## 📍 THE CHOLA ADMINISTRATION (Central & Provincial) 📌

- 🗺️➡️ **The Ultimate Revision Flow Chart:**
    - Chola system of administration was highly organised and efficient ➔ king was the pivot of administration and all authority rested in his hands ➔ Central Government: king was most important person as all authority was vested in him ➔ but he had Council of Ministers to advise him ➔ king often went on tours to keep check on administration ➔ officers were paid by giving them assignments in revenue-bearing lands ➔ princes were associated with ruling sovereigns and actively employed in peace and war ➔ Central government looked after external defence, internal peace and order, promotion of general prosperity and cultural progress of empire ➔ Provincial Government: Chola empire divided into mandalams or provinces ➔ these further divided into valanadu and nadu ➔ Princes of royal family appointed governors of provinces. 🏛️📜

## 📍 LOCAL SELF-GOVERNMENT 📌

- 🗺️➡️ **The Ultimate Revision Flow Chart:**
    - Cholas were good administrators believing in local self-government ➔ in many villages administration carried out not by government officials but by villagers themselves ➔ villages had three types of village assemblies (ur, sabha and nagaram) ➔ long inscriptions on walls of some village temples give details of how ur and sabha were organised ➔ ur was common type of assembly where land was held

by all classes of people (members of local assembly) ➔ sabha was exclusively brahmin assembly where all land belonged to brahmins ➔ nagaram was assembly of merchants belonging to localities where traders/merchants were in dominant position ➔ villagers who owned land were chosen by vote to the council ➔ life and work of villages discussed in these councils (source of popular strength because it united people) ➔ all affairs concerning village such as collection of taxes, settlement of disputes and allocation of water looked after by committees. 🤝🏘️

## 📍 TEMPLES AS SOCIAL CENTRES & EDUCATION 📌

- 🗺️➡️ **The Ultimate Revision Flow Chart:**
    - (Imp) Temples in Chola kingdom were the centre of social activities ➔ not only place of worship but place where people gathered for various social activities ➔ some temples owned huge lands and participated in inland/overseas trade ➔ lands donated to temples known as devadaya or devadana ➔ in some cases land-revenue of certain villages was assigned to temple and villagers instructed to pay land-revenue in produce and gold to temple treasury ➔ temples were biggest employers after the State providing work/livelihood to large number of people ➔ temples took care of welfare of workers by providing food, clothing, housing, arranging proper education and establishing hospitals ➔ temple was also a centre for education ➔ priests were local teachers as there were no separate schools ➔ schools housed in temple courtyard ➔ students learnt lessons in two languages (Sanskrit and Tamil) ➔ religious teaching was in Sanskrit since texts such as Vedas had to be studied ➔ students learnt Tamil which was widely spoken in Chola kingdom ➔ Tamil was influenced by Sanskrit and gradually incorporated Sanskrit words. 🛕📚

## 📍 THE REVENUE 📌

- 🗺️➡️ **The Ultimate Revision Flow Chart:**
    - Revenue of Chola kingdom came from taxes on land, produce of land and tax on trade ➔ part of revenue kept for king ➔ rest used on

public works (building roads/tanks), salaries of officials, paying for upkeep of army, and building of temples ➔ taxes on land collected by officials from village councils. 💰🌾

## 📍 THE CHOLA ART & TEMPLES 📌

- 🗺️➡️ **The Ultimate Revision Flow Chart:**
    - Chola art represents finest enduring expressions of artistic excellence in early medieval South India ➔ developed under patronage of Chola dynasty (ruled Tamil region and extended influence across Sri Lanka/Southeast Asia between 9th and 13th centuries CE) ➔ achievement made possible by political stability, economic prosperity and strong administrative system ➔ art was closely intertwined with religion (especially Shaivism and lesser extent Vaishnavism) ➔ temples functioned as centres of social, cultural and economic life ➔ Royal patronage played major role with rulers like Rajaraja Chola I and Rajendra Chola I building grand stone temples, bronze images, murals and inscriptions ➔ works reflect deep spiritual devotion and desire to express imperial power and royal prestige ➔ Chola artists achieved remarkable balance between idealism and realism (reality) ➔ works display technical perfection, harmonious proportions (designing), rhythmic movement and refined ornamentation ➔ occupies central place in history of Indian art due to lasting influence ➔ Chola Temples: most built in Dravidian style ➔ at heart of temple lies garbhagriha (sanctum) where main deity is installed ➔ directly above it rises vimana (tall pyramidal tower which is most striking feature) ➔ vimana crowned by shikhara (dome-like structure) and finally topped with kalasha (symbolic finial) ➔ in front of sanctum is ardha mandapa leading to spacious mandapa (pillared hall used for rituals/assemblies) ➔ surrounding sanctum is prakara (enclosed corridor for circumambulation) ➔ large temples include Nandi mandapa housing sacred bull Nandi facing main shrine. 🎨⛩️

## 🧠 High-Yield Fact Table (The Ultimate MCQ Solver) 📌

| Term / Name / Concept 🏷️ | Direct Fact / Detail 📝 |
|---|---|
| **Brihadeshwara Temple** | The best example (ex: 1) of Chola temples, located at Thanjavur and built by Rajaraja I; topped with a single block of stone weighing about 80 tons. |
| **Gangaikonda-Cholapuram Temple** | Another fine example (ex: 2) of Chola architecture built by the Cholas in their capital. |
| **Lost-wax Technique** | Method used to create Chola bronze sculptures, allowing for great flexibility and delicate detailing. |
| **Nataraja** | The most celebrated Chola bronze image (icon), depicting Shiva as the cosmic dancer. |
| **Damru** | Small hourglass-shaped drum held by Shiva, symbolising the rhythm of creation. |
| **Agni** | Fire held in Shiva's other hand, representing destruction. |
| **Abhaya Mudra** | Hand gesture shown by one hand, assuring protection to devotees. |
| **Apasmara** | The dwarf crushed under Shiva's foot, symbolising ignorance. |
| **Prabhamandala** | A circle of flames surrounding the Nataraja figure, representing cosmic energy. |

| Term / Name / Concept 🏷️ | Direct Fact / Detail 📝 |
|---|---|
| **Devakoshtas** | Sunken wall spaces on the outer walls of the sanctum where Chola stone sculpture is mainly seen. |
| **Airavatesvara Temple** | Located at Kumbakonam; a remarkable example of detailed stone carving where sculpture and architecture merge seamlessly. |
| **Fresco Technique** | Method used to paint murals on lime-plastered surfaces in Chola temples. |
| **Nayanars** | Shaiva saints whose portraits, along with stories from the Puranas, were mainly shown in Chola paintings. |

## 📍 CHOLA TEMPLES (Examples) 📌

- 🗺️➡️ **The Ultimate Revision Flow Chart:**
  - The best example (ex: 1) of Chola temples is the Brihadeshwara or Shiva Temple at Thanjavur built by the Chola king, Rajaraja I ➔ it is a wonderful piece of architecture ➔ its top is crowned with a single block of stone about 25 feet high and weighing about 80 tons ➔ there is another temple (ex: 2) built by the Cholas in their capital Gangaikonda-Cholapuram ➔ it is a fine example of the Chola architecture ➔ the walls of the temples were decorated with carved images of gods and goddesses ➔ the design and paintings on the walls of these temples are good specimens of art. 🛕🪨

## 📍 CHOLA SCULPTURE (Bronze & Stone) 📌

- 🗺️➡️ **The Ultimate Revision Flow Chart:**
  - Chola bronze sculptures represent the highest level of artistic refinement in metal art ➔ these images were created using the lost-wax technique ➔ which allowed great flexibility and delicate

detailing ➔ the most celebrated image is Nataraja, depicting Shiva as the cosmic dancer (natural) ➔ in this form, Shiva holds a small hourglass shaped drum called the damru in one hand, symbolising the rhythm of creation ➔ while agni or fire in another hand representing destruction ➔ one hand is shown in abhaya mudra, assuring protection to devotees ➔ the raised foot signifies liberation or moksha ➔ while the other foot crushes Apasmara, the dwarf symbolising ignorance ➔ surrounding the figure is the prabhamandala, a circle of flames representing cosmic energy ➔ flowing hair and balanced posture convey movement, grace, and divine power ➔ and make the Chola bronzes both spiritual icons and masterpieces of art ➔ Chola stone sculpture is mainly seen on temple walls, pillars, and niches ➔ sculptures are placed in devakoshtas (sunken wall spaces) on the outer walls of the sanctum, each housing a deity figure ➔ these panels depict gods, goddesses, saints, dancers, musicians, and scenes from the Puranas and epics ➔ the figures are deeply carved and show natural body proportions, soft expressions, and a sense of rhythmic movement ➔ decorative designs like flower motifs, geometric patterns, and ornamental borders enhance their beauty ➔ a remarkable example of such detailed stone carving can be seen in the Airavatesvara Temple at Kumbakonam, where sculpture and architecture merge seamlessly. 🗿🔥

## 📍 THE PAINTINGS 📌

- 🗺️➡️ **The Ultimate Revision Flow Chart:**
    - The paintings of the Chola period form an important though relatively lesser-known part of Chola Art ➔ most of the surviving paintings belong to the eleventh century and were found beneath later paintings on the walls of the Brihadeshwara Temple ➔ these murals were painted on lime-plastered surfaces using the fresco technique ➔ they mainly show religious themes, such as stories from the Puranas and portraits of Shaiva saints called the Nayanars ➔ the figures have soft outlines, long eyes, and calm expressions ➔ natural colours like red, yellow, green, and black

were used, giving the paintings a simple and graceful look ➔ (page shift engaged) ➔ architecture shows the Chola artists' sense of balance and proportion. 🎨🖌️

## 📍 DECORATIVE ARTS & METALWORK 📌

- 🗺️➡️ **The Ultimate Revision Flow Chart:**
    - Along with paintings the Cholas were skilled in decorative arts that added beauty to their temples ➔ decorative designs can be seen on pillars, ceilings, doorways and walls ➔ these include flowers, creepers, patterns, mythical animals and sacred symbols which were meaningful and reflected religious ideas ➔ the way decoration was carefully blended with metalwork was another important decorative art of the Cholas ➔ besides famous bronze statues, craftsmen made lamps, bells, vessels, and jewellery for temple use ➔ these objects show fine workmanship and skill ➔ together, Chola paintings and decorative arts show a fine combination of devotion, beauty, and craftsmanship. 🌸⚒️